

Director of Pfizer India, a subsidiary of the US major, says that given the extensive footprint of global pharma companies in India and the rise of their Indian counterparts, the sector offers women plenty of roles and career opportunities, ranging from office-based roles to customer-facing ones that require travel.

“We tend to see a greater diversity in the office-based roles including research & development, medical affairs, marketing, human resources, and finance primarily due to the predictability of working hours and the flexibility in working from home as needed,” says Nevatia, an MBA from IIM Ahmedabad, with extensive experience in sales, marketing, and business leadership positions at McKinsey and Novartis Pharma, among others.

Ameera Shah, Promoter and Managing Director of Metropolis Healthcare, which runs a chain of diagnostic laboratories, slices the answer into two segments: women joining at the junior level and those in leadership positions. “The former’s motivation to have a career in the healthcare or pharma sector stems from job safety, job security, the absence of rigid timelines, and more predictable working hours, leading to a healthier work-life balance,” says Shah. “Moreover, the industry

fosters a culture of care and empathy, creating a female-friendly environment,” she says. Shah says women looking for leadership roles in pharma and healthcare need business sense and the ability to integrate scientific principles into the business landscape.

According to government data, women are significant in India’s healthcare system, contributing to 70-80 per cent of the services. In India, women have historically dominated nursing and allied health professions.

Dr Vandana Lal, Executive Director at diagnostic chain Dr Lal PathLabs Ltd, a family business that has turned professional, says: “As the healthcare sector evolves, many women are moving from purely technical to techno-managerial roles and excelling as executive leaders.” An MBBS with an MD in pathology, Lal says many women are drawn to healthcare because of an intrinsic desire to positively impact people’s lives and contribute to the community’s well-being.

“The ability to serve others gives women a sense of fulfilment and career satisfaction.... They have better soft skills, and the healthcare field, being an essential service, requires such a dedicated workforce,” says Lal, whose husband, Dr Arvind Lal, son of the founder, is

WOMEN POWER

Leadership and aggregate female representation in select healthcare sub-sectors

	LEADERSHIP REPRESENTATION*	AGGREGATE REPRESENTATION#
	WOMEN IN LEADERSHIP POSITIONS	WOMEN IN OVERALL WORKFORCE
● Private hospitals	25-30%	54%
● Diagnostics	15-25%	30%
● Pharmacies/distributors	10%	10-15%
● Healthtech	10-30%	30-40%
● Pharma & biotech	5-10%	8%
● Medical equipment and supplies	10-20%	15-20%
● Financial institutions (insurance)	10%	20-30%

#AGGREGATE REPRESENTATION IS TAKEN FROM DATA OF 107 ORGANISATIONS AND LEADERSHIP REPRESENTATION IS TAKEN FROM DATA OF 26 ORGANISATIONS

*FOR LEADERSHIP ROLES, C-SUITE, HEADS OF BUSINESSES AND FUNCTIONS, HODs, MEDICAL DIRECTOR, DEAN, SVPs, ETC. ARE CONSIDERED

SOURCE DASRA WOMEN IN LEADERSHIP REPORT